

than the next promotion. He looked at me the way he might look at someone who had just suggested he jump off the Golden Gate Bridge. He figured he would work eleven more years, to age 65. He had a big house, young children to support. How could he retire?

Two weeks later I went back to the hospital. Perry told me he had been reflecting a little. His father and brother had died in their 50s. One died in his office, the other on the golf course with a client. Perry said he didn't want that kind of fate. Who says you need another promotion? Who says you have to work until age 65? You could be dead by age 65.

Once back at work, Perry thought more about retiring. He added up his net worth, talked to his wife and children, and mused about what he might like to do. He discovered he really didn't need any more money. He found out his 14-year-old was desperate to move back to the United States and saw his wife weep tears of joy when she heard of the idea.

The break came when the home office decided to close Perry's Brazilian operation. Perry was offered jobs in Mexico or Argentina or an early retirement package. He went for the retirement deal the way an eagle swoops to grab its prey.

Lyle is 38, married for the second time, and has no children by either marriage. Lyle's a tough, tireless, hands-on manager. Since taking an M.B.A. from Wharton in 1972 he's changed jobs five times. Each was a calculated move dictated by his private game plan. In his most recent incarnation he was a \$200,000-a-year president of a Cleveland-based auto-parts subsidiary. He traveled four days a week from office to office, customer to customer.

Shortly after taking his new job Lyle told me he was wearing himself out at work. He planned to retire as soon as he had a million dollars. I suggested that a lower amount would do, but Lyle felt he would have to sacrifice too much. And anyway, he'd have the million in three or four years.